BBC LEARNING ENGLISH

6 Minute English
Learning from different generations

This is not a word-for-word transcript.

Phil
Hi Georgie.

Georgie
Hi Phil.

Phil
So, Georgie, do you often spend time with people who are much older than you or much younger than you?

Georgie
I do, actually, because I'm in a choir, so there's quite a wide range of ages – lots of older people, lots of younger people.

Phil
We can call an age group of people a **generation**. And you might feel that it's difficult to understand or agree with people from a different **generation**. Today on 6 Minute English, we're going to be finding out about a project that is gathering together the oldest people – that's those that are retired – with the youngest, and that's children who attend nursery. And we'll be asking the question, 'What can we learn from different **generations**?' Let's start with our quiz question, Georgie. What **generation** would someone born in 1982 be in? Is it:

a) Generation X,
b) Millennial, or
c) Gen Z.

Georgie
Phil, I'm going to go with Generation X.

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Phil
OK. Well, we will find out the answer at the end of the programme.

Georgie
OK. Phil, so you said we're going to look at a project which gets small children interacting with older retired people. So, how does it work?

Phil
Well, in Chester, in the northwest of England, a nursery has opened up in a retirement village. There's the usual nursery staff to look after the children, but the older residents can join in for activities as well. There's a library, a cafeteria and a garden for the children and the older people to share, and some of the older people or 'grand-friends', as the children call them, lead some of the activities, like dance or crafts. And presenter of BBC World Service podcast People Fixing the World, Myra Anubi, went to visit the special nursery and spoke to some of the participants.

Myra Anubi
Ian was once a fighter pilot, and getting involved in the nursery has helped him **fill a void**.

Ian
It was after my wife died last year. It seemed I had a big, big hole to fill. And the people down in the nursery, they phoned me up and said, "We were doing **such and such** a thing. Why don't you come and join us?" And that's what I've been doing. So, yes, and I've enjoyed it. And I find it very interesting to see how they develop.

Myra Anubi
One of the things I **heard from the grapevine** is that you help the children make paper planes.

Ian
That's right.

Georgie
Myra says that the nursery helped Ian **fill a void** after his wife sadly died. If you **fill a void**, you find something to help you feel better after a loss.

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Phil
Ian explains that after his wife died, staff at the nursery would phone him to tell him about the daily activities, which he refers to as **such and such**. And that's an expression that we use to talk about something without giving a specific example.

Georgie
It sounds like Ian has enjoyed spending time with the children at the nursery, and Myra tells him she's **heard from the grapevine** that he's been teaching the children to make paper planes.

Phil
Yes, **hear from the grapevine** is an expression, meaning that something is a rumour. And we also say, **hear on the grapevine**.

Georgie
Well, this nursery sounds like a really lovely project, Phil. What is the impact it's having on the older and younger people?

Phil
Well, the charity Ready Generations, which runs the nursery, says it works with universities to study the effects of mixing **generations** on health and wellbeing, and they say they've seen positive results. And there have been studies around the world on projects that encourage different **generations** to mix, and they found that they can help reduce loneliness, improve how healthy and well people feel, and even boost learning and creativity. People Fixing the World host Myra spoke to Liz Ludden, co-founder of the nursery in Chester, about the differences that she's noticed since it opened.

Myra Anubi
And as I realised, these interactions also seem to be **breaking down stereotypes**.

Liz Ludden
Your first thought would be how **lively** and energetic young children can be, and what we found is so can older people. And so sometimes, you know, it's the older people that we're saying, "Can we just calm this down a little bit?"

Georgie
Myra says the nursery **breaks down stereotypes**. This means it provides evidence that common beliefs about a group of people are not true.

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Phil
For example, a stereotype about **generations** is that younger people are **lively**, meaning they're loud and have lots of energy, whereas older people are not that **lively**.

Georgie
Right. But in the nursery, Liz says it's often the older people who have lots of energy and are being noisy rather than the children. The staff even have to tell them to calm down sometimes!

Phil
So, Georgie, is that something that you found in your choir?

Georgie
Actually, yes. The older people in my choir are big characters. It's often them who are dragging us all to the pub...!

Phil
OK. Georgie, I think it's time to look at the answer for that question. I asked if someone was born in 1982, which **generation** would they be from?

Georgie
I said Generation X.

Phil
OK. Well, actually, I'm afraid the answer was b) – they're a Millennial, just like you!

Georgie
Ah...! OK. Let's recap the vocabulary we learned in this programme, starting with **generation**, which is a group of people who are of a similar age.

Phil
Fill a void means find something to help you feel better after experiencing loss.

Georgie
Such and such is a way to talk about something without giving a specific example.

Phil
If you **hear** something **on the grapevine**, you hear a rumour.

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Georgie
The expression **break down stereotypes** means find evidence that common beliefs about a group of people are untrue.

Phil
And **lively** means loud and with lots of energy.

Georgie
Once again, our six minutes are up, but you can test what you've learned with the worksheet on our website. Go to bbclearningenglish.com.

Phil
Thanks for joining us and goodbye.

Georgie
Goodbye!

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VOCABULARY

generation
group of people who are of a similar age

fill a void
help to feel better after experiencing loss

such and such
reference to something without giving a specific example

hear on the grapevine
hear a rumour

break down stereotypes
find evidence that common beliefs about a group of people are untrue

lively
loud and with lots of energy

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